

L^AT_EX for Elegant Humanities Handouts in Conferences and Classrooms

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Abstract

L^AT_EX has been popular throughout the mathematical and physical sciences for decades. L^AT_EX's utility for scholars in humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked. In this tutorial, I introduce the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in humanities scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs, such as poetry and translations. The specific example is preparing a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with excerpts of ancient Greek and parallel English translations. Ultimately, I aim to inspire colleagues in religious, historical, philosophical, and related areas to think of L^AT_EX as having a wide range of professional applications even inside these scholarly fields in which L^AT_EX is not widespread.

1 Introduction

The world's best established software system for typesetting and document formatting, L^AT_EX has been popular throughout mathematical and physical sciences for decades. The utility of L^AT_EX for humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked. L^AT_EX can be used for typesetting in most instances in which a scholar of humanities needs to present materials. Whether one works in history, philosophy, literature, or some other discipline in which L^AT_EX is not usually employed, L^AT_EX is nevertheless worth the investment of time to learn.

Granted, in disciplines outside the mathematical and physical sciences, such as my own area of historical theology (technically, divinities rather than humanities), editors expect us to prepare our materials for publications with bug-for-bug compatibility with Microsoft Word for back-and-forth markup. In practice, this expectation requires us to use word processors, such as LibreOffice Writer. A word processor presents material in a What You See Is What You Get (WYSIWYG, “whizzy-wig”) style. While one writes, one is simultaneously thinking about and working on formatting.

In a typesetting language, such as L^AT_EX (or ConT_EXt or Typst, either of which a scholar might also choose for various reasons), one is only concerned about the structure of what one is writing. One declares that specific characters will be in certain categories of writing ‘things’ (heading, paragraph, footnote, accent type, typeface, and so on), and one allows the program to compile one's writing as ‘code’

into a tidy final document — every time. Preparing a *curriculum vitae*, conference handout, or other document with unusual typesetting requirements becomes about the writing itself rather than the formatting.

To learn L^AT_EX as a scholar outside the disciplines in which L^AT_EX is the norm, I recommend working through one of two community-built, libre guidebooks. The first, which I used to learn L^AT_EX, is *The Not So Short Introduction to L^AT_EX* (github.com/oetiker/lshort). The second, which a colleague of mine recommends, is *Modern L^AT_EX* (github.com/mrkline/modern-latex). Either guidebook may be used to begin to learn how to typeset cover letters, ancient languages, and other materials that are relevant across the humanities — without the front-loading of mathematics and physical sciences that one finds in other general introductions.

To show how thinking about digital typesetting in terms of document structure rather than final format can be of practical use in the humanities, here I present a tutorial in which I introduce the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in humanities scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs. The thought experiment is that of determining how to prepare a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with perfectly organized excerpts of a Byzantine Greek text and an original English translation in parallel.

2 Simplest parallel text in L^AT_EX

There are many ways to set parallel text in L^AT_EX. The simplest is to use the community package called `parallel`, which is included in T_EX Live, MiK_T_EX, and other L^AT_EX distributions. For full documentation, visit <https://ctan.org/pkg/parallel>.

To start using `parallel` in any L^AT_EX document, include the following in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{parallel}

For example, here is an abbreviation of the preamble to the Beamer file for my talk at TEX Users Group 2026 (github.com/historical-theology/latex-talks/) with only the most important entries, including parallel:

\documentclass[aspectratio=169]{beamer}
\usetheme{Goettingen}

\usepackage{parallel}

\title{\LaTeX for Elegant Humanities Handouts
  \ in Conferences and Classrooms }
\author{Corey Stephan, Ph.D.}

\begin{document}
```

This is the basic format for parallel text set with the package `parallel`:

```
\begin{Parallel}\<left space>\<right space>
\ParallelLText{\<left text row 1>}
\ParallelRText{\<right text row 1>}
\ParallelPar
\ParallelLText{\<left text row 2>}
[and so on]
\end{Parallel}
```

I (a theologian) might typeset the opening words of the Christian prayer *Ave Maria* in their traditional Latin with parallel English like so:

```
\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}
\ParallelLText{Ave Maria,}
\ParallelRText{Hail Mary,}
\ParallelPar
\ParallelLText{gratia plena,}
\ParallelRText{full of grace,}
\ParallelPar
\end{Parallel}
```

Here is the result:

3 Advanced parallel text in L^AT_EX

For advanced scholarly setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX, especially long-form (e.g. a critical edition with accompanying translation), one ought to learn the two interconnected and frequently updated community packages **reledpar** (for parallel typesetting specifically) and **reledmac** (for typesetting academic editions in general), which are bundled with T_EX Live and other L^AT_EX distributions.

reledpar and **reledmac** are purpose-built for long-form academic parallel texts. These two packages are meant to replace older methods of academic parallel text preparation in L^AT_EX that one might find in Web searches. For full documentation, visit ctan.org/pkg/reledpar and ctan.org/pkg/reledmac.

4 Setting non-Latin characters in L^AT_EX

The most important packages for handling text outside Latin alphabets are **babel** and **polyglossia**, which are included in T_EX Live and other L^AT_EX distributions. Although it is possible to convert a project from one of these metapackages to the other, a scholar ought to invest the time to choose carefully between either of these two at the start of a long-form project.

4.1 babel vs. polyglossia

In *The L^AT_EX Companion: 3rd Edition* (Addison-Wesley, 2023), Frank Mittelbach and Ulrike Fischer

suggest that despite the fact that **babel** is older than **polyglossia**, **babel** generally is preferable: “Unless you are in a special situation where a language or script is notably better supported by **polyglossia**, the recommendation is to use **babel** with all engines” (entry 13.7.2, “Polyglossia”). Since **babel** technically supports the same languages as **polyglossia**, a situation in which one would need **polyglossia** over **babel** will be rare. Yet, a scholar working with ancient languages might have such a rare situation.

In (old) Web forum discussions, one might read that **babel** will work better with LuaL^AT_EX, whereas **polyglossia** will work better with XeL^AT_EX. In 2026, however, one may choose either of the two mainline L^AT_EX engines that are built with full Unicode support, that is, XeL^AT_EX or LuaL^AT_EX, for **babel** or **polyglossia**. Results might vary, however, depending on the specifics of a given project.

To make an informed choice against a specific set of requirements for a given academic undertaking, one should explore each package’s documentation at ctan.org/pkg/babel and ctan.org/pkg/polyglossia.

To learn **babel**, I recommend Chapter 13: “Localizing documents” in *The L^AT_EX Companion: 3rd Edition* by Mittelbach and Fischer, which succinctly introduces localization in L^AT_EX via **babel** in a practical, didactic (teaching) style.

To learn **polyglossia**, I recommend the package’s official documentation in CTAN.

5 Starting a project with polyglossia

Here, I will model **polyglossia**, which is what I happen to be familiar with using for polytonic (ancient and Byzantine) Greek.

First, include the package in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{polyglossia}
```

Then, after the beginning of the document but before actual type, declare the languages and their variants. For example, here is this .tex file’s **polyglossia** declarations:

```
\begin{document}
\setdefaultlanguage{english}
\setotherlanguage[variant=ancient]{greek}
```

One is able to use one of the ‘other’ declared languages (in this case, ancient Greek) by toggling it when needed.

A language may be toggled for a long excerpt like so:

```
\begin{greek}
<greek text>
...
\end{greek}
```

Hail Mary, full of grace.

For example, here is the famous opening to John's Gospel:

```
\begin{greek}
      , \\\
      , \\\
      . \\\
\end{greek}

      ,
      ,
      .
```

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